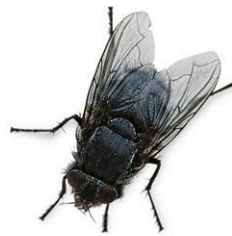




ROOF SPACES

THE HOUSE MOUSE, originally from central Asia, has spread all over the world. Other household rodents include rats and some species of dormice.

FOR GECKOS, house walls make good nocturnal hunting grounds—especially if there are lights nearby to attract flying insects.



HOUSEFLIES enter buildings to find food, but some other species—such as the cluster fly—use attics and undisturbed empty rooms for hibernation.



COCKROACHES can become a serious pest in warm parts of the world and in houses with central heating.

SILVERFISH are widespread but largely harmless. They feed nocturnally on all kinds of starchy substances, from flour to wallpaper paste.



THE DADDY-LONG-LEGS SPIDER is found in caves in the wild. Cellars and dark rooms make perfect artificial alternatives.

Indoors

In the natural world, many animals inadvertently create habitats for other species when they build their nests. Humans do exactly the same. However, because our “nests” are so extensive and complex, they can host an exceptionally wide range of animal life. Much of it is harmless, but some can cause problems or at least inconvenience.

Most indoor animals are small and nocturnal, which helps them to avoid being noticed by their human hosts. This is especially true of species that share daily living areas and that scavenge leftover food.

Silverfish, for example, emerge after dark to search for flour and other starchy produce, scuttling away if cupboards or drawers are suddenly opened, exposing them to the light. Cockroaches behave in a similar way, but they are more of a nuisance because they spread disease. At dawn, nocturnal animals hide away, leaving the day shift to take over. Houseflies, for example, are most active during the day because they navigate by sight.

In basements and attics, wildlife is less affected by the cycle of light and dark, and it is less frequently disturbed by human comings and goings. For wild animals, attics resemble extra-large tree holes, while basements resemble caves. Wasps, birds, and house mice will all nest in attics—if they can get in—and they sometimes share this habitat with roosting bats. Basements and cellars provide a haven for spiders, which can survive for long periods without food and, in many cases, catch their prey in total darkness.

The advent of central heating has been an important factor in the increase in the number of animals that choose to share our homes. For example, cockroaches, which were originally found mainly in warm parts of the world, are now widespread in cooler regions. Soft furnishings and carpeting also play a part: as well as helping keep the home warm, they provide hiding places and nesting material for various animals.

URBAN HAZARDS

Urban animals face a form of “unnatural selection” in that any species that are not suited to city life are ruthlessly weeded out, regardless of how successful they would be in the wild. Shortage of space, combined with noise and pollution prevent many animals from establishing themselves in cities, while other environmental factors, such as bright street lighting, deter many more. Such are the hazards of city life that even experienced, and otherwise successful, urban animals sometimes succumb to the dangers. Traffic, of course, is a major hazard that

claims the lives of thousands of animals (including humans) every day.



PARTING OF THE WAYS

Urban traffic is a major hazard to animals, but roads are just as much of a threat in rural areas. They divide natural habitats, separating animal populations that normally interbreed.



LIVING AREAS



BASEMENTS